

Declaration of ethical AI use for assignments

School of General Education- BRAC University

Weight- 5% of the Assignment Grade

Students are instructed to complete this form with sincerity, declaring that they have used AI in an ethical manner and as a learning tool to support the successful completion of this assignment. Completion of this form accounts for 5% of the total grade of this assignment. Failure to submit a declaration or an incomplete form will result in 0%.

AI is a tool to enhance and support your work, not to replace your own critical thinking, analysis, and creative effort. The final product must be a result of your/ your team's intellectual and creative labor. All AI use must be openly declared.

I hereby acknowledge that I have used the following Generative AI tools in the below described capacity to complete my assignment Food Ethnography: Everyday Politics for the CST301: For the Love of Food course which was due on 18th November.

Part I: Student-declared AI awareness

Mention the AI tools that were used as support tools for this assignment (i.e., ChatGPT, Co-Pilot, Gamma, Gemini etc.)	ChatGPT, Claude
Please write the initial ‘prompts’ you provided to the AI tool (i.e., “I am writing a book review for my course Emergence of Bangladesh. The book is titled X by Y. Please help me write a well-structured academic review of this book”)	1. What is food ethnography? 2. Correct the grammar. 3. What is the question saying? 4. Suggest me better synonyms. 5. Rate my assignment, tell me about the weak part. 6. Did I answer all the questions? 7. Give me the citation for this paper.

Part II: Instructor-approved options for AI use (Instructions for faculty: You may revise this list of options to fit your respective course/ assignment)

You are only allowed to use the aforementioned AI tools to **support** the following activities related to this assignment. Please choose carefully and **put a tick against the options** you have chosen to use AI for:

☐ Brainstorming Ideas

☐ Generating Outlines

- ☒ Editing Grammar and Style
- ☐ Summarizing Texts
- ☒ Formatting Citations
- ☒ Translating Texts

- ☒ Analyzing Data
- ☐ Generating Visual Aids
- ☐ Research Assistance (Finding secondary sources)

Part III: Instructor-approved AI restrictions *(Instructions for faculty: You may revise this list of options to fit your respective course/ assignment)*

You are **NOT** allowed to use AI for the following activities.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1. Submitting AI-Generated Work as Original | 7. Violating Assignment Instructions |
| 2. Paraphrasing (Quillbot etc.) | 8. Plagiarizing with AI |
| 3. Falsifying Citations | 9. Automating Group Work |
| 4. Producing Unedited AI Content | 10. Creating Misleading Visuals |
| 5. Bypassing Critical Thinking | 11. Submitting AI-Generated Creative Work |
| 6. Generating False Data | |

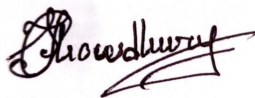
Part IV: Penalties *(Instructions for faculty: You may revise this list to fit your respective course/ assignment)*

Penalties for these violations include:

- Requirement to revise and resubmit work, potentially with a grade penalty.
- A failing grade on the assignment
- A reduced course grade.
- Referral to the Proctor's Office for disciplinary action

I understand the terms and conditions of this declaration and I hereby acknowledge that the information provided by me on this form is true and correct to the best of my knowledge.

Samia Tabassum Chowdhury - 22301206



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Name, ID, & Signature of the student



Mid-term

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Section : 03

CST301 : For the Love of Food

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Food Ethnography: Everyday Politics

Food is not only the substance to digest, it is something that indicates culture, rituals, norms, morality intersect that in the same point. The food ethnography explains how food preparation, cleanliness standards, and body norms somehow determine significant relationships as well as divide the house. The tales of self-sacrificing love, sacrifice and protest, are hidden under the accustomed sounds of chopping, stirring, and pouring. This paper reveals how societies discipline bodies through food, create barriers between inclusion and exclusion and cultivate emotions that bring us together or tear us apart through food. The power of religion, ritual purity and gender oppression are interrelated to create the invisible systems that are not only controlling the kitchens but also souls. The example of the "Ramadan Feast" presents the connection of these forces in the same area that is profoundly sacred yet highly disputed in the world of faith and flesh.

The Ramadan Kitchen

During Ramadan, Muslims worldwide fast from sunrise to sunset as an act of being disciplined, sacrificing and serving Allah. These thirty days by Muslim families are devoted to prayer, self-denial and renewal. The kitchen, particularly, is transformed into the center of religious and domestic activity where faith and food meet and the materialistic need is opposed by the state of mindfulness and care

In Bengali Muslim families, the women take the head responsibility of the kitchen for these thirty days, where mothers are in the main supervision. They wake up early and cook suhoor, the pre-dawn meal which finishes with the Fajr Adhan and keeps the family going all day long during the fast. Even during the fasting, they are busy working on the evening meal known as iftar by which Muslims break the fast after the Maghrib Adhan. These women willingly carry on with their job, no matter how tired, hungry and exhausted they are, they just do for their families devotionally, symbolizing their labor as spiritual service to their families.

This is a social practice that has domestic and ritualistic meaning. The role of women is to prepare and serve the meal hygienically in time to ensure that all the dishes are satisfactory to the family and maintain religious values. All fasting family members, including men, women, and children gather for iftar, to share meals together is a strong practice that strengthens the bond and mutual religious beliefs. Unlike commercial or public food preparation, this is a sacred form of domestic labor in which devotion of women nourishes both the body and spirit during the blessed month of Ramadan.

Gendered Kitchen Labor: Purity Taboos, Modesty Codes, and Serving Hierarchies in Ramadan

In Bangladesh, approximately over 90 percent of households follow a gendered arrangement of labor in Ramadan, with women responsible for all kitchen-related activities, food preparation and family care. As the family members are without food and water through a long period, meal planning and health consideration are highly important. Women handle these tasks efficiently and over time this has become a deeply rooted social norm. Today it is an accepted norm that the kitchen of Ramadan should be run by women.

This gendered power is also supported by bodily regulations. Menstruating women are exempted from fasting under Islamic law. This creates strong tension because women are fully responsible for kitchen work but at times their bodies make them “unfit” for this duty. However, most of the traditional Bengali families do not allow those women to cook or touch food because of menstrual blood that is considered to be the kind of contamination. Other families forbid menstruating women to enter the kitchen at all whereas some ones permit them to participate with severe hygienic conditions. Women usually maneuver their way around them without raising an alarm. Either they keep their menstrual situation a secret to prevent tensions in their families or they have to deal with the equally embarrassing fact of being treated as “impure” during the most sanctified month. In most cases, in order to be able to uphold food hygiene and purity, menstruating women will not cook on their own, however they oversee kitchen chores actively. During Ramadan month, both men and women help in serving iftar meals, although the main responsibility is left to women to prepare food and manage the kitchen.

During Ramadan, the holiest month, all Muslims are supposed to follow a standard of modesty. The purity of the body should be deeply inside the believer through their devotions, and the outside through clothes and behavior. Those who prepare Ramadan meals are also supposed to cover their hair and put on clean clothes even in the kitchen. Although it is summer, physical strain of fasting and the tiredness caused by the workload in long hours, the fatigue, dehydration and hunger are often ignored as natural endurance. By this weariness, however, they wholeheartedly try to maintain proper cleanliness and modesty.

The segregation of labor based on gender is also rigid. Women typically eat after ensuring all family members have been served which is one way of molding them as being self-sacrificing nurturers, other than being equal partners. Such hierarchy is normalized as norm of a group of cultural discourses that identify the exhaustion of women as the virtue of spirituality and feminine piety. However, in contemporary Bengali Muslim households, these bodily taboos are slowly fading away as modern generations refuse to believe in menstrual stigma, allowing women to deal Ramadan kitchen responsibilities with dignity rather than shame.

Halal Authority, Ritual Purity, Pollution and Sacred Inclusion in Ramadan

To Muslims, consuming haram food is prohibited. Halal food is quite available in Bangladesh, however, in non-Muslim countries, it is a daily struggle to manage Halal food. Ramadan kitchen is a sacred space where the boundaries of inclusion and exclusion are arranged on the basis of Halal and haram. All ingredients must be Halal and meat must be slaughtered according to Islamic practices. Both genders ensure grocery purchases are Halal-certified, excluding all non-permissible substances from Ramadan meals. Islamic principles require verifying Halal certification before purchase, ensuring Ramadan meals exclude all non-permissible substances. As Mukherjee (2014, p. 23) says, Halal is not limited to meat; it is comprehensive in all aspects of existence, is an exalted concern of prohibition that allegedly consolidates the moral, spiritual, and physical being of people, an example of how purity requirements are used as a tool of total body and spiritual regulation. Sacred authority in the Ramadan household is negotiated among elder family members who hold religious interpretive power and validate Halal practices, determining who can participate in kitchen activities and under what conditions. This authority creates inclusion for family members who demonstrate proper religious knowledge and bodily purity, while excluding menstruating women or those unfamiliar with Halal practices from participating in sacred food preparation. Menstruating women are temporarily restricted in certain homes due to the issue of contamination and therefore women's inclusion becomes contingent on their bodily condition and male religious authority instead of their role of being indispensable in household nourishment during the Ramadan. According to Osim and Eteng (2021, p. 122), ritual purity in Islam called “Tahara”, recognize two forms of ritual unfitness: bodily acts like defecation, sexual intercourse, and menstruation that temporarily remove individuals from ritual readiness, and inherently impure substances that contaminate spaces, persons, or objects, disqualifying them for sacred use. This changes the belonging of women into conditional belonging thus their bodies occasionally define who could access the space they are in charge of sustaining.

Purity of the Ramadan rituals defines physical and emotional boundaries in the family. It means proper preparation and serving of Halal foods with hygiene and it is a form of worship before Allah. The kitchen becomes the sanctified space where food preparation becomes worship. The hygienic presentation of the food and immaculate cleanliness of the kitchen are the criteria, because any failure can jeopardise the religious purity of the food. Commensality is the key aspect of ritual purity of Ramadan which means sharing meals reflects social relationships, cultural practices. On top of all these, larger concerns of ritual pollution which dictate the way the Ramadan feast is structured. Food from outside during iftar or suhoor is a cause of concern because the handling and preparation of those foods might endanger ritual purity as well as health. Similarly, it is also believed that serving stale food during the iftar table is also a contamination of the table which jeopardizes the purity of the Ramadan table. To ensure contamination is avoided women should vigilantly monitor and maintain the purity of Ramadan food.

The commensality of Ramadan meals shapes social relations as the sharing of food appears egalitarian. Iftar brings the family together in sharing food which fills with intimacy and natural connection. Appadurai (1981, p. 496) argues that food can serve to indicate and construct social relations characterized by “equality, intimacy, or solidarity” or sustain relations characterized by “rank, distance, or segmentation.” As such, the collective meal during Ramadan is both a religious communion and a construction of a boundary. Among the practices that take place during this month, the family persons usually participate in iftar together on the floor with a mat that does not only support the Islamic values but also creates a strong link between people that enhances Islamic beauty of a family. The majority of the families maintain the right distance when having iftar. In most families, males and females eat iftar in separate rooms to save decency and privacy following the Islamic principles. The division also allows women to have iftar comfortably. The cooking skills and ability to arrange successful Ramadan foodstuff can provide the women with admired domestic authority, becoming major organizers of the family sanctity and social order. Purity, norms brings question about hierarchy and equality but everyone who fasts is spiritually equal in his/her devotion, Halal authority remains hierarchical.

Food as Moral Regulation, Gendered Labor, Boundaries and Emotional Life in Ramadan Practice

Purity and Halal practice reflects a strong commitment of Muslims as a witness of their devotion. Nevertheless, there remain a major contradiction of moral regularity. When families spend too much time on preparing iftar meals and cooking much more than is required, the spiritual meaning of purity is lost in material wealth and hospitality. Further, Muslims who are fasting in non-Muslim countries also experience an even more pathetic situation. Some shops sell Haram food in the name of Halal for money. Nevertheless, to consume non-Halal food at iftar knowingly or unknowingly because of a lack of availability and the certain sources, directly violating the standards that should define their moral bodies. These practices reveal the performative and conditional nature of the body as a moral surface, made dependable as need be but negotiable when economic or social or geographic pressures are exerted and the deep mismatches between the ideals of religion and the realities of practice..

It is purely the role of women due to their effective management of household duties with love and devotion, which society has exploited to ensure entire responsibility. Over the years, the attitude of domination in men has been clearly evident in Bengali society and gendered food labor has created hierarchy making women's huge work invisible and their suffering. The females get up earlier than the rest of the family and cook during the fasting and dehydration process and then they present the iftar. This subjectivity generates the naturalization of this subordination by religious discourse that morphs inequality into feminine responsibility. Men's minimal participation is disproportionately valued as religious authority where women are the implementers of the religious authority under the male spiritual authority. Still, Ramadan food responsibility disputes hierarchy too.

Cooking is an art that women have perfected which means that they cannot be replaced. Women in present generations juggle these roles as they work outside also. Their indispensable labor at Ramadan has already determined their fundamental value.

Ramadan food practices create powerful barriers for groups, classes and communities. The primary religious boundary separates "us," Muslims consuming only Halal food and fasting properly, from "them," non-Muslims and Muslims who compromise by eating Haram or non-Halal items. Class boundaries emerge where wealthy families displaying elaborate iftars with abundant dishes become "us," the truly pious and blessed, while poor families with simple meals are marked as "them," economically and spiritually inferior despite equal devotion. Cultural boundaries distinguish "us," Bengali Muslims maintaining strict standards at home, from "them," diaspora Muslims sometimes consume non-halal food abroad. Generational divisions position traditional elders as "us," guardians of authentic Islam, against modern youth as "them," potentially corrupting traditions. Spatial boundaries make the kitchen interior "us" space, pure and family-centered, while outside food represents "them" territory, contaminating and dangerous. Mukherjee (2014, p. 68-69) defines Halal as a flexible and dynamic political, social, and bodily boundary that safeguards the Muslim community by creating a mobile barrier against external forces at the most basic level of food consumption, demonstrating how the dietary patterns are the new focal point of imposing religious and cultural differences across the borders. Pride glorifies the high achievers while shame the underperform, disgust reinforces wall between the pure insiders and the contaminating outsiders. The paradox is striking, a month meant to unite Muslims in shared sacrifice, creates countless divisions, proving that food never merely nourishes bodies but always sorts souls into hierarchies of belonging.

Ritual purity and Halal practices during Ramadan kitchen not only depend on food and devotion but also affect emotional states which extensively governs social life. The efforts of women in keeping Halal standards and ritual purity reflects strong devotion because food preparation becomes a form of worship and spiritual service to the family. The ability to organize suitable Ramadan brings religious credit and social acceptance which brings fulfillment and a sense of belonging. Nonetheless, violation of these norms raise strong negative feelings. The preparation of stale food, having outside food of questionable Halal quality or unintentionally violating the rules of purity provokes strong shame and anxiety, undermining the high moral and social value of iftar. Again, commensality amplifies these emotional registers, which is the result of joint eating that brings happiness of experience and closeness and of ritual isolation at the cost of religious reverence. These criss-cross emotions has turned the everyday food practices into an inclusive emotional system that organizes the moral judgment, social belonging and daily conduct and makes obedience not only obligatory but also emotionally satisfying and self-controlling.

Ramadan uncovers a vast food practice that is rooted with purity. A purity that extends beyond food itself, it also cleanses the mind, fosters love and solidarity among people, deepens faith and belief in the Almighty. “Ramadan feast” exemplifies vividly the food ethnographic situation that speaks of authority, culture, purity, and long-held practice. Yet within these very constraints there is the silent strength of women who, in their sacramental work, keep alive not only in the physical body but also the spirit of faith, kinship, care for family and belongings that even boundaries may never fully extinguish.

Reference

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